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The Two-Edged Sword: Gender and Religious Freedom in

Rachel Speght's "A Mouzell for Melastomus"

"A Mouzell for Melastomus" is one of the cornerstones of early English feminist writings and played a crucial role in fighting for the freedom of female voices and actions in the 17th century. This key pamphlet, prominent in the English Pamphlet Wars, came about in large part from the religious and social innovations that occurred during the Protestant Reformation and created the conditions necessary for Speght's voice to be unleashed. Through the social and religious reforms that occurred during the Protestant Reformation, Rachel Speght's "A Mouzell for Melastomus" could operate as both a stirring defence of the rights and innate worth of women as well as a prime example of the need for religious freedom.

Rachel Speght was born in London in 1597 to a Calvinist family. As her own father was a Calvinist minister, Speght's upbringing was directly impacted in two crucial ways. First, she was taught both by her father and other tutors in the Classics, which was highly unusual for a woman at that time. Helen Speight mentions this irregularity of Speght's education in her article "Rachel Speght's Polemical Life" due to the intensity and comprehensive scope of Rachel Speght's education. She states, "Rachel's education was unusual for a young woman of her time and social position for its thoroughness, and exceptional in that it was based on classical curriculum" (Speight 1). Secondly, she was brought up in a home where religious discourse was commonly

featured. With her father as a minister, Rachel Speght's education was formed and based off of Christian religious principles. As such, when Joseph Swetnam published "The Araignment of Lewde, Idle, Froward and Unconstant Women", Rachel Speght not only had easy access to the debates around the nature of women and Eve in connection with Swetnam's argument, due to her advanced education, but she also had the academic and religious training to understand where Swetnam mistranslated and misinterpreted the Bible. This would give her an incredible advantage as she entered into the frenzied writing scene of the English Pamphlet Wars.

The English Pamphlet Wars began as a way to discuss religious, political, and economic struggles that were facing the nation and happened alongside the Protestant Reformation. The wars started with the famous Protestant leader Martin Luther beginning the separation from the Catholic church and forming the Protestant church. The tensions would build as King Henry VIII formed the Church of England as a further split from the Catholic church. As this separation from Church and State in England becomes more pronounced, several individuals start to write and produce pamphlets that are widely produced and widely read across Britain (Mark 1). While the beginning of these tracts was focused mostly on religious issues and separation, the Pamphlet Wars would soon begin to address a wide range of subjects from political authority, gender equality, and large scale moral concerns. These pamphlet wars would span from 1520AD-1689AD and would include such notable authors as William Tyndale, Thomas More, John Milton, and Thomas Hobbes (Mark 1).

This religious and political England is the sphere in which Rachel Speght is going to begin to write her "A Mouzell for Melastomus". Speght's "A Mouzell for Melastomus" can be divided cleanly into three main sections. At the beginning of her pamphlet, Speght directly addresses the misogynist text "The Araignment of Lewde, Idle, Froward and Unconstant

Women” and how her argument will reduce and refute his and other prominent misogynist claims about women. This leads into Speght’s second argument that women are not to be considered sinners and held responsible for the fall of Adam and Eve, but that women are instead the pinnacle of God’s creation and deserve to be treated as such. Finally, Speght then moves forward to argue for the equality of gender both in personal and private spheres. She clearly states that an individual must be judged based on their own virtues and vices, and said individuals are not to be held to unreasonable standards based on their gender.

Each of Rachel Speght’s claims within “A Mouzell for Melastomus” can be directly shown as impacted by the Protestant Reformation across Europe. Her direct rebuttal of Joseph Swetnam’s work was made possible because of the Protestant belief that all should have the ability and access to interpret scripture according to their understanding. Secondly, Speght’s argument about the fall of Adam and Eve arose from the concept of Sola Scriptura, that the scriptures are the ultimate source of inspiration and guidance, which principle of Protestantism Speght will lean on to support her argument about Adam and Eve. Speght’s final argument for the equality of gender came from the Protestant belief of rational judgement and that each individual will be judged by God and not man. As Speght continues to frame her argument of this defence of women, it becomes clear that the Protestant Reformation played a key role in impacting her views on gender equality and the need for religious freedom.

As the impact of the Protestant Reformation is shown on Rachel Speght’s “A Mouzell for Melastomus”, the pamphlet turns from a sole defence of women and their rights to rational thought, as it originally appears to be, into a text that advocates for an individual’s right to religious individuality. Speght is using the vehicle of gender equality, which was a commonly discussed topic throughout the English Pamphlet Wars, and weaponizing it to advocate for the

need for religious thought and freedom. As Rachel Speght was heavily impacted personally by the Protestant Reformation, which ended up leading into her personal Calvinist beliefs, so too her pamphlet reflects the religious balance and thought that came through the Protestant Reformation. Throughout “A Mouzell for Melastomus”, Rachel Speght uses her pamphlet on the nature of gender equality to be a vehicle for helping to encourage the advocacy of religious freedom that occurred during the Protestant Reformation. This is seen from the very beginning of her argument as she begins to address the misogynistic views that were widely presented and popularized by Joseph Swetnam.

In order to best craft her argument in favor of gender and religious freedom, Rachel Speght begins her pamphlet by addressing the four main arguments dismissing women on the basis of religion during the English Pamphlet Wars. These arguments focused on the inherent evil of women as they were descendants of Eve and their ability to lead men into temptation. In a concise and logical manner, Speght lists these four points from Swetnam’s argument, who was one of the biggest voices against gender equality, clearly as follows:

First, that woman, though created good, yet by giving ear to Satan's temptation, brought death & misery upon all her posterity.

Secondly, that Adam was not deceived, but that the woman was deceived, and was in the transgression.

Thirdly, that Saint Paul says, It were good for a man not to touch a woman.

Fourthly, and lastly, that of Salomon, who seems to speak against all of our sex; I have found one man of a thousand, but a woman among them all have I not found, whereof in it[s] due place. (Speght 1)

In order to refute these claims on gender, Speght addresses each of the following claims by directly quoting from and using scriptural logic. By pairing her arguments of the nature of women alongside scripture, Speght is clearly showing both the virtue of gender equality and the need for religious freedom. In order to combat the first claim that women bring death and misery upon all mankind, Speght quotes both Genesis in explaining how “Their eyes were opened,” and later goes on to quote Paul in showing of Christ “that his mercy was equivalent to both Sexes. . . that male and female are all one in Christ Jesus” (Speght 2). In order to address the second claim that only Eve was deceived by Satan and fell into transgression, Speght builds off of the argument of Paul by stating, “that as in Adam all die, so in Christ shall all be made alive” (Speght 2). Speght continues to show through scriptural evidence that the claims about females are not only rationally incorrect but religiously incorrect as well. By exercising her religious education and freedom, Speght is able to brilliantly weave these defences of gender with the Biblical scriptures she had access to in order to deliver a fatal blow to Swetnam’s argument.

Speght continues to address the third argument about women by showing the background of the Apostle Paul’s comments about touching and interacting with women. Speght provides both historical context to the situation around the people of Corinth as well as continuing to use Biblical references to back up her claim (Speght 2). She finishes that portion of the argument by powerfully stating, “Paul was afterward married himself, the which is very probable, being that interrogatively he says, Have we not power to lead about a wife, being a sister, as well as the rest of the Apostles, and as the brethren of the Lord and Cephas?” (Speght 2). Speght here is placing herself alongside the religious disciples of Jesus Christ by arguing and paving a place for female

voices. Just as Jesus Christ needed female disciples during His day, Speght argues that female disciples and leaders are still needed currently.

In speaking of Rachel Swetnam's impressive ability to weave the scriptural passages with political arguments, Elizabeth Delmonico's essay titled "Defences of Women" states, "Speght cannot ignore the claim in Corinthians that 'man is the womans Head.'" Instead, she attempts to locate woman properly within God's hierarchy. Eve's relative weakness, for example, makes her less culpable than Adam. In attacking Swetnam's scriptural citations, Speght practices an exact yet creative exegesis" (Delmonico 610). As opposed to ignoring the Biblical passages used against her arguments, Speght instead uses them to show how both women should have the freedom to express themselves and uses scriptures to back up her claims.

Finally, Rachel Speght addresses the final and fourth argument that women will inherently lead men to sin and moral impurity by providing the factual case behind why Solomon fell. She states, "These women [were] turning his heart away from being perfect with the Lord his God", and that "his assertion is to be holden a part of the confession his former follies" (Speght 2). Here Speght brilliantly takes the erroneous claims about women being supposedly always in sin, disregards them, and finally illuminates the specific claims found within the often misquotation by Solomon. Righetti, in her article "How Women Wrote about Themselves: A Corpus-informed Comparison of Women Writers' Defences in Sixteenth- and Seventeenth-century England", continues to show the forcible defence of women found in Rachel Speght's clear and informed argument and in her refutations of Swetnam. Righetti explains, "Rachel Speght's 'A Mouzell for Melastomus' has been described as a clear and recognizable starting-point from which to speak as a woman. It provides a neat line of argumentation and legitimizes the display of humanist education which is essential for

Swetnam's ungodly syncretism and addressing more complicated and sensitive topics, such as Protestant theories of marriage" (Righetti 47).

In structuring her refutations against commonly held misogynist beliefs of the day, Rachel Speght clearly shows two ways in which her writings have been influenced by the Protestant Reformation and religion as a whole. First, Speght uses rational thought and correctly quoted scriptures to back up her statements, which heralds back to the Protestant belief of Sola Scriptura. Secondly, by the emergence of female voices previous to Rachel Speght's day at the beginning of the Protestant Reformation, Rachel Speght had the ability to voice her refutations in a clear and respected way. The combination of these two elements, quoted scripture and freed female voices, help to echo Speght's points for equality in gender and religion within "A Mouzell for Melastomus".

Sola Scriptura, when translated from Latin, is the Protestant belief that truth comes ultimately from the scriptures, primarily the Bible, and is a key tool in Rachel Speght's arguments for religious and gender freedom. This key principle of Protestantism focuses on not only aligning with the Bible in word, but that every action an individual takes must be a reflection of the teaching that comes from scripture. John MacArthur, who is a current Protestant theologian, professor, and minister at The Master's Seminary stated regarding Sola Scriptura that "Sola Scriptura simply means that all truth necessary for our salvation and spiritual life is taught either explicitly or implicitly in Scripture. . . Therefore, Scripture is the highest and supreme authority on any matter on which it speaks" (MacArthur 1).

This core belief in Sola Scriptura that arose during the Protestant Reformation is shown clearly throughout "A Mouzell for Melastomus". Throughout Speght's arguments against Swetnam, she continually cites scripture as the solution and form of ultimate authority against

the claims about women. When she continues to address topics such as duties in marriage or the need for individual rationality, Rachel Speght continually refers back to Biblical individuals or passages to reinforce her points. As Speght continuously uses her belief in *Sola Scriptura*, she advocates for religious freedom in the ability to interpret scripture for oneself, but she also illuminates the benefits of the Protestant Reformation as she uses *Sola Scriptura* as a vehicle to advance her argumentative points.

Secondly, in patterning her main argument in the form of stating the arguments of her opponents then the refutals, Rachel Speght is aligning herself with other female writers who were emerging across Europe in the wake of the Protestant Reformation. One such writer was Christine de Pizan, who not only helped to settle court arguments in the French courts, but she would also go on to publish one of the first clear arguments for not only the defence of women, but it would also pave the way for female writers to not only be poets and novelists but academic writers as well. Christine de Pizan would become known as one of the first female political and argumentative writers. Her defences about the nature of women and for gender equality would directly impact Rachel Speght's "A Mouzell for Melastomus" as those very public arguments paved the way for the discussion of gender equality that became the spring board for Speght's later argument.

For a closer contemporary to Rachel Speght, Ester Sowernam emerges as a secondary voice against Swetnam's misogynistic text. Like Speght, Sowernam would first address Swetnam's claims in her pamphlet "Ester Hath Hanged Haman: or an answere to a lewd pamphlet, entituled, the arraignment of women, with the arraignment of lewd, idle, froward, and unconstant men, and husbands" and would then go one step further by pairing her arguments alongside Greek Classics and scriptures to defend womanhood. Sowernam's arguments, like

Speght's, would be based out of the Bible as the source of truth and authority, and would help to further the belief that women could be advocates for religious and gender equality.

These female voices, powered by the emergence of the Protestant Reformation, would be a powerful influence on the themes of gender equality found in "A Mouzell for Melastomus". Just as Christine De Pizan was clear and direct in her arguments for the innate worth and benefit of women, Speght's argument of women is based not out of women's worth in society or to men but in their innate worth as individuals. Just as Esther Sowernam would use the scriptures to defend her argument, Rachel Speght would gain her voice in the English Pamphlet Wars largely in part to her consistently excellent use of scripture in her arguments.

Rachel Speght was able to express herself clearly and effectively about gender and religious freedom throughout her pamphlet because she was not only building her argument and stance off of these two female authors, but on the backs of the Protestant Reformation as a whole. Throughout the Protestant Reformation, there was a strong outcry for religious freedom and the ability to form one's own relationship to deity. Within Helmer's essay, "Putting the Protest Back into Protestant", Helmer helps to clearly show the fight for truth and reason during the Protestant Revolution that paved the way for religious and social reform. Helmer states, "The use of reason is important for the public discussion of truth and necessary for the functioning of a democracy. The robust intellectual tradition characterizing mainline Protestantism must not be lost" (Helmer 1). This "robust intellectual tradition" that Helmer speaks of begins to pave the way for writers like Rachel Speght to come along and expand traditionally held beliefs about the nature of religion and female rights (Helmer 1).

Following the main arguments against women found in Swetnam's pamphlet, the second main point that Speght made in "A Mouzell for Melastomus" comes from the account of the

creation of women found in Genesis and helps to fight clearly for religious and gender equality. Speght first begins her argument that God was the “glorious Creator” and saw fit to “effect a worthy creature” speaking of the creation of both Adam and Eve (Speght 3). Speght then goes on to pair men, who were seen as the highest of God’s creations, right alongside women in equality. Speght states, “For as God gave man a lofty countenance, that he might look up toward Heaven, so did he likewise give unto woman” (Speght 3). Speght finishes her argument about the creation of women when she states that the “end, for which woman was made, was to glorify God, and so be a collateral companion for man to glorify God, in using her body, and all the parts, powers, and faculties thereof, as instruments for his honor” (Speght 3).

In this defense of women as being merited for who they are individually in relation to God, Speght will go on to explain that men and women are to be judged individually for their own virtues and vices and not just because of the fall of Adam and Eve. In doing this, Speght is claiming reason and responsibility as the highest determining factors in an individual’s worth. This was a radical change of thought as previously held beliefs stated that men, but most especially women, were to be held accountable for the fall of Adam and Eve in the Garden of Eden. From Speght’s argument, no longer would women be considered sinners and heathens because of the fall of Adam and Eve, but they would need to be considered based on their own thoughts and actions.

In showing reason and virtue as the highest ways for individuals to judge and be judged, Rachel Speght is also clearly arguing for the need for religious thought and reason. As the Protestant Reformation spread across Europe, so did the idea that individuals can now think and act for themselves without being subject to the Catholic church as being the end all authority (Mark 1). Individuals should not only be reliant on a priest or pastor to think for themselves

about their relationship with God, but thanks to the Protestant Reformation, individuals can now reasonably fight for their own relationship with God. Because of the Protestant Reformation, individuals could form their own relationship to deity and their own ability to think and process both scriptures and academia for themselves.

Rachel Speght is clearly building off of this principle of individual action and individual relationship to deity as she is detailing the creation of women. This moment helps to transform “A Mouzell for Melastomus” into less of a defense of women and more into a defense of religious thought and capacity. As the creation of women is viewed through the lens of a religious defence pamphlet and less of a gender defence, lines speaking of God as “so excellent a workman as the Lord” and “workman which is perfectly good” begin to show the subtle additional argument that Speght is making in “A Mouzell for Melastomus”(Speght 3). If God, as Speght describes, is the ultimate craftsman and creator and has made each individual on the earth, it stands to reason to Speght that individuals would want to have their own relationship with him to gain the additional reason and enlightenment that comes from pairing oneself with deity.

This moment of Rachel Speght using gender equality as a vehicle to champion for religious freedom becomes a prime example within “A Mouzell for Melastomus” and Speght’s argument of her argument becoming a two-edged sword to both fight for the defence of women and to fight for the individual’s relationship with deity. As she balances these two vastly different social and political issues by pairing them together, Speght has found an intersection between politics and religion and then carved that intersection wide open to show what equality for both would look like in Speght’s idealized society.

In explaining how this two-edged sword of religious and gender equality could be used so compellingly by Rachel Speght, Christine Malcolmson wrote in her book *Debating Gender in Early Modern England, 1500–1700* that “The marginalized position of women in relation to the debate, outside the university and church, gave them some ability to disrupt its terms” (Malcolmson 15). As Rachel Speght was not only one of the first female polemicists in Europe but also a religious minority as a Calvinist, her social position gave her the ability to both clearly speak her mind about divisive issues like gender and religious inequality, but it also gave her more clout behind the arguments that she made. Here, Speght’s life alongside the Protestant Reformation begins to show the virtue and need for individual thought and reason. As Speght was able to advocate so clearly for these pressing issues of gender and religious freedom through her individual reason, she shows and paves a way for others, regardless of gender, to be able to follow.

Finally, in Rachel Speght’s concluding portion of her argument, she states clearly not only the responsibilities of women but also the responsibilities of men with both a focus on gender and religious equality. She begins by stating that the “end for which woman was made, was to be a Companion and helper for man”(Speght 3). In her continuance of reciting Biblical passages, Speght goes on to say, “for a good wife, says Plautus, is the wealth of the mind, and the welfare of the heart; and therefore a meet associate for her husband; And Woman, says Paul, is the glory of the man” to continue to show the responsibilities of the woman, wife, and mother (Speght 3). Throughout these quotes, Speght is beginning to weave delicately both sides of her argument for gender and religious equality. By starting with the understood duties of women in England, Rachel Speght forms a strong launching point by which to address the continuing gender inequality as she appeals to the commonly held beliefs of her day.

However, Speght does not just outline the duties of women but goes on to outline, quite radically for her day, the responsibilities too for men. She begins by stating that men must “remember the duties they are to perform in being heads” and not to be “thinking themselves Lords & Rulers” over their households (Speght 3). In this moment, Speght begins to show that men should not dominate their households but lead and guide them towards a deeper relationship with deity. Speght goes on to leave the readers with this startling question, “And what greater ingratitude can be showed unto God then the opprobrious speeches and disgraceful invectives, which some diabolical natures doe frame against women?” (Speght 3). Here Speght is showing the dishonor it is to God to mock His creation in women. In not only commenting on the nature of the roles of women but also of the roles of men, Rachel Speght begins to, as she claims in her argument, yoke men and women as oxen pulling in the same direction towards the same goal (Speght 3). Speght is also yoking together here her argument for religious and gender equality.

These bold claims for gender equality emerge in Speght’s “A Mouzell for Melatomus” due to two main event that were occurring alongside the Protestant Reformation: the ascension of Elizabeth I to the throne, which would become one of the great equalizers of gender equality previous to the Renaissance, and the new Protestant belief that everyone, regardless of gender, should have access to the Bible. These moments within the Protestant Reformation help to show clearly the yoking of men and women that Rachel Speght was advocating for as the highest form of gender equality.

Queen Elizabeth I was born in 1533 and reigned until her passing in 1603, 14 years before the publication of “A Mouzell for Melastomus”. Her reign became influential for showing what a woman in political and religious power could accomplish. No longer could it be claimed that women were incapable of leading or of rational thought because Queen Elizabeth stood as a

direct example of the negation to that idea. Her reign, right during the height of the Protestant Reformation, was also crucial as she denounced the Catholic beliefs that were commonly held within the ruling class and was instead Protestant herself. Now, even the queen of England advocated for religious individuality and reason. Allison Heisch wrote in her essay “Queen Elizabeth I and the Persistence of Patriarchy”, “That for those who admired her, perhaps especially those who admired her from afar, Elizabeth must have seemed very much like a goddess, not only after her lifetime, but also during her reign” (Heisch 46). This idolization of Queen Elizabeth came not only from her acts as queen but also from the way she represented the ideal female ruler as a reformist and equalizer. As Queen Elizabeth I stood as an icon of religious reform, her example would pave the way for Rachel Speght to begin her arguments for gender equality.

Secondly, as the Protestant Reformation argued that all people should have the opportunity to read and interpret scripture, one of the largest obstacles blocking female education was becoming eradicated. Previous to this point, the majority of men who were able to read and interpret scriptures were all priests or higher for the Catholic church. Not only was it difficult to get the training on how to read and write in Latin, it was considered heretical to attempt to do so as a female. With the Protestant Reformation and the beginning of biblical translations into German and later English, more people would now have the ability to learn and read from their believed ultimate source of truth in God, which now finally included women and especially Rachel Speght.

These two facts of the Protestant Reformation with Queen Elizabeth I ascending to the throne and the liberation of the Bible to now being read widely directly impacted the writings of Rachel Speght and especially her pamphlet “A Mouzell for Melastomus”. By the women that

emerged as writers and leaders before Rachel Speght began publishing her works, Speght was able to see in the distance the gender equality that she was so passionately defending in “A Mouzell for Melastomus”. With the emergence of the Bible in German and English, people were able to learn spiritual truths for themselves and be able to judge Speght’s argument from a place of religious understanding. This translation of the Bible also allowed the people to be able to find their own religious beliefs, just as Rachel Speght had been arguing for. Thus the Protestant Reformation also gave Rachel Speght the ability to advocate for religious freedom and use the new religious tools that emerged with the reformation.

Ultimately, the virtue of Rachel Speght’s “A Mouzell for Melastomus” is that it is both a compelling defence of women and a compelling argument for religious freedom. Through the impact of the Protestant Reformation, Speght’s voice was able to be unleashed, creating the first female English polemist in the process. Joshua Mark, a writer from The World Encyclopedia stated about this power of the Protestant Reformation that “The Protestant Reformation completely changed the European cultural, religious, social, and political landscape and is often referred to as the birth of the modern age as it coincided with and was encouraged by the Renaissance of the 15th-16th centuries” (Mark 1). Just as the Protestant Reformation changed cultures, as Mark states, it also changed Rachel Speght and the ways in which she was able to shape and control her argument to best advocate for religious and gender based freedom.

In pairing her defence of women alongside the defence of religious beliefs that were becoming more common place within her day, Speght’s bold claims about the creation of women, judgement based off of individual worth, and gender equality became more palatable both to the era hostile to female writers that she was writing in and encouraging to the female writers who were emerge from her writings. Ultimately, Speght’s genius in pairing these

arguments together would help “A Mouzell for Melastomus” to become that cornerstone of early English feminist writings. This two-edged sword of gender and religious equality found in Speght’s “A Mouzell for Melastomus” would become the hallmark of Speght’s polemical life and become an inspiration for generations of female writers to follow as they too would be an advocate for change in the many spheres of life.

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